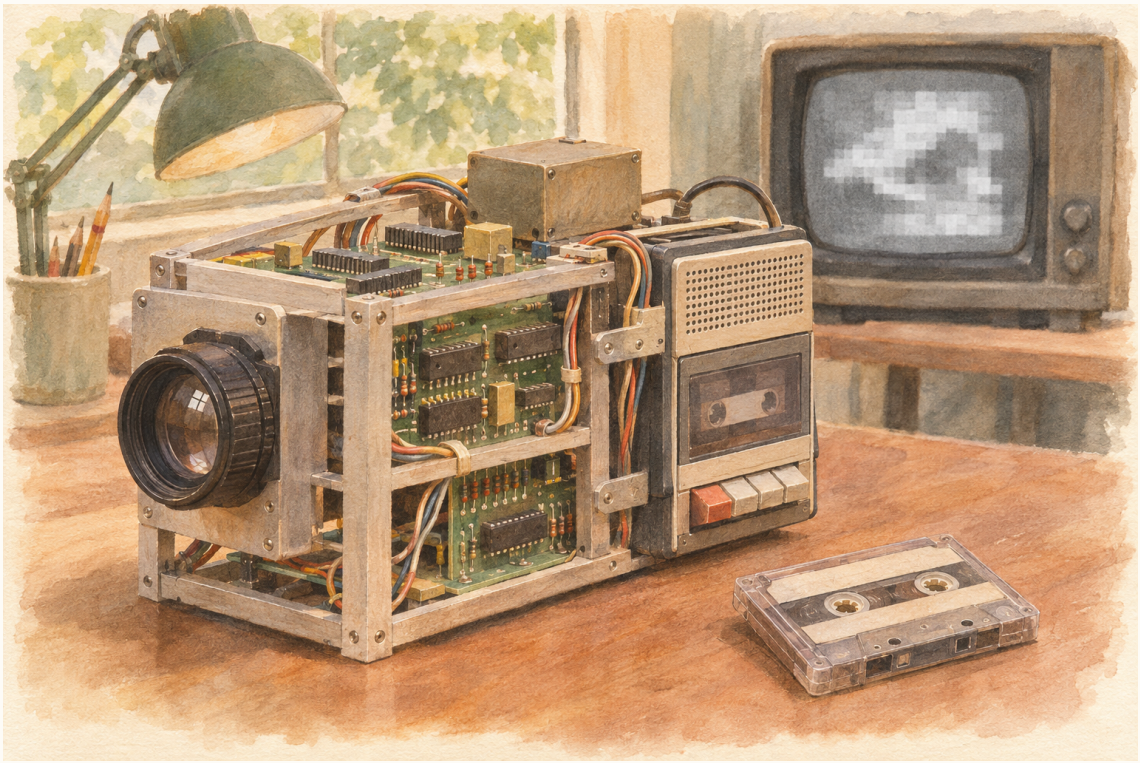
发明了数码相机，却被它打败

The Company That Invented Its Own Killer



造出数码相机的公司，为什么仍被数码时代冲击？

READ 纯净阅读

CHECK 中文核对

LEARN 词汇记忆

RECALL 回想巩固

英文原文

In 1975 Kodak engineer Steven Sasson built the first digital camera. The toaster-sized gadget, a cumbersome heavyweight of about eight pounds, was hardly portable, let alone handheld. Its first rudimentary picture held 10,000 black-and-white pixels. Recording it on a cassette took 23 seconds, and a playback unit showed it on a television.

Kodak's revenues showed its dependence on film, the profitable pillar of its business. Technical staffers were appreciative of the camera, but it needed no film. By Sasson's recollection, his superiors at headquarters called it cute and urged him to keep it hushed. A patent followed in 1978. Production never did.

The advent of digital photography proved disruptive. In June 2009 Kodak said it would stop making Kodachrome, its analogue film, citing lessened demand in the digital era. Kodak's manpower had reached an apex of about 145,000 in the 1980s. By 2012, layoffs since 2003 had slashed 47,000 jobs, alongside the shutdown of 13 factories and some 130 labs.

On 19 January 2012 the 131-year-old firm sought Chapter 11 protection from its creditors, sapped by pension costs and years of slowness in going digital. Citigroup, a lender, provided $950 million for its restructuring. A portfolio of 1,100 digital imaging patents fetched about $525 million from a consortium of twelve buyers, including the giants Apple and Google.

After 19 months of reorganisation, the once-mighty Kodak left bankruptcy in September 2013, downsized, streamlined, and refocused as a commercial printer for business clients. In November 2009 President Obama had decorated Sasson with national laurels, commending his digital camera. That medal's year also saw Kodak announce the end of Kodachrome.

中文译文

1975年，柯达工程师史蒂文·萨松造出第一台数码相机。这台烤面包机大小的装置是个约八磅重的笨重大块头，几乎谈不上便携，更不用说手持。它的第一张粗糙照片只有一万个黑白像素；把照片记录到盒式磁带上需要23秒，再由回放装置显示在电视上。

柯达的营收显示，公司依赖胶卷这项利润支柱。技术人员很欣赏这台相机，可它不需要胶卷。据萨松回忆，总部上司说它挺可爱，却让他别声张。1978年，相机取得专利，但这台原型机始终没有投产。

数码摄影的问世带来颠覆性冲击。2009年6月，柯达宣布将停产Kodachrome这一传统胶卷产品，理由是数码时代需求减少。公司员工规模曾在20世纪80年代达到约14.5万人的顶峰。到2012年，自2003年起的裁员已削减4.7万个岗位，同时关闭了13家工厂与约130个冲印实验室。

养老金成本与多年数码转型迟缓不断削弱公司。2012年1月19日，这家拥有131年历史的企业申请美国《破产法》第11章保护，以免债权人追讨。贷款方花旗集团提供9.5亿美元用于重组。包括苹果、谷歌等巨头在内的十二家买方组成财团，以约5.25亿美元买下1100项数字成像专利组成的专利组合。

经过19个月重组，昔日强大的柯达于2013年9月走出破产程序：缩小规模、精简业务，重新聚焦于为企业客户提供商业印刷服务。早在2009年11月，奥巴马总统就授予萨松国家级荣誉，表彰他的数码相机。而在这枚奖章颁发的同一年，柯达也宣布了Kodachrome胶卷的终结。

史实说明：这是2009年度的国家技术与创新奖章，实际颁发日为2010年11月17日（白宫典礼记录）。柯达宣布停产Kodachrome是在2009年，因此两件事并非发生于同一年。

核心词汇

先记这22项。连着下方的原文短语一起回想。

cumbersome adj.
笨重的
a cumbersome heavyweight

rudimentary adj.
初步的；粗陋的
Its first rudimentary picture

revenue n.
营收
Kodak's revenues

dependence on 名词短语
对……的依赖
its dependence on film

profitable adj.
盈利的；赚钱的
the profitable pillar of its business

appreciative of 形容词短语
欣赏；赞赏
appreciative of the camera

recollection n.
回忆
By Sasson's recollection

keep … hushed 动词短语
对此保密；别声张
urged him to keep it hushed

patent n.
专利
A patent followed in 1978

advent n.
出现；问世
The advent of digital photography

disruptive adj.
颠覆性的
proved disruptive

layoff n.
裁员
layoffs since 2003

creditor n.
债权人
protection from its creditors

sap v.
逐渐削弱
sapped by pension costs

restructuring n.
重组
for its restructuring

portfolio n.
一组持有的资产；此指专利组合
A portfolio of 1,100

consortium n.
财团；联合体
a consortium of twelve buyers

reorganisation n.
重组；改组
19 months of reorganisation

downsize v.
缩小规模
downsized, streamlined

streamline v.
精简
downsized, streamlined

refocus as 动词短语
重新定位为
refocused as a commercial printer

commend v.
表彰
commending his digital camera

文中词汇与搭配

补充词汇共33项。保留每个表达在本文中的意思。

digital camera 名词短语
数码相机

toaster n.
烤面包机

gadget n.
小装置

heavyweight n.
重家伙；大块头

portable adj.
便携的

let alone 固定短语
更不用说

handheld adj.
手持的

pixel n.
像素

cassette n.
盒式磁带

playback n.
回放

pillar n.
支柱

staffer n.
员工

superior n.
上司

headquarters n.
总部

analogue adj.
模拟式的；此处指传统胶片

lessen v.
减少

era n.
时代

manpower n.
员工规模；人力

apex n.
顶峰

slash v.
大幅削减

shutdown n.
关闭

pension n.
养老金

slowness n.
迟缓

lender n.
贷款方

buyer n.
买方

giant n.
行业巨头

once-mighty adj.
昔日强大的

printer n.
印刷企业；不是打印机

client n.
客户

decorate v.
授予荣誉；授勋

laurels n.
荣誉

medal n.
奖章

the end of 名词短语
……的终结

回想与回顾

先遮住下方答案，再把四个词放回原文。

01 The _____ of digital photography proved disruptive.

02 By Sasson's _____, his superiors at headquarters called it cute and urged him to keep it hushed.

03 Citigroup, a lender, provided $950 million for its _____.

04 downsized, _____, and refocused as a commercial printer for business clients.

文章主线

- 先机 1975年，柯达工程师萨松造出第一台数码相机：约八磅重、一万黑白像素，存一张照片需23秒。
- 牵制 胶卷是利润支柱；据萨松回忆，上司让他别声张。原型机1978年获专利，却未投产。
- 衰退 数码摄影冲击胶卷需求，转型迟缓与养老金负担削弱公司，柯达于2012年申请破产保护。
- 重组 柯达获9.5亿美元贷款，并以约5.25亿美元出售1100项专利；2013年完成重组，转做企业印刷。
- 反差 柯达2009年宣布停产Kodachrome胶卷；萨松获2009年度美国国家技术与创新奖章，实际于2010年授勋。

参考答案　1 advent 2 recollection 3 restructuring 4 streamlined